THE RISE OF DUTCH SEA POWER

IN THE FIRST HALF of the 17th century the sailors of the Dutch United Provinces, in rebellion against the rule of Habsburg Spain, were the world's most formidable sea fighters. Their best commanders—men such as Piet Heyn and Maarten Tromp—showed a combination of seamanship and ruthless aggression that their enemies, although sailing in larger warships, could not match. Dutch naval victories helped force the Spanish to conclude a 12-year truce in 1609. Meanwhile the fleet of the Dutch East India Company supplanted the Portuguese in the Indian Ocean and East Asia, forcibly seizing control of the valuable spice trade. By the time the war with Spain resumed, the Dutch had used increasing wealth to finance naval expansion. The Dutch West India Company, established in 1621, harassed the Spanish and Portuguese in the New World, occupying part of Brazil and, in 1628, capturing the entire Spanish treasure fleet. A stunning victory over the Spanish at the Downs in 1639 confirmed Dutch naval supremacy and rendered inevitable Spain's eventual acknowledgement of Dutch independence.

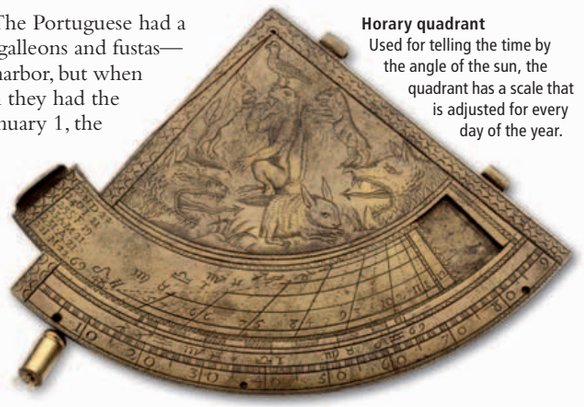
DUTCH–PORTUGUESE WAR

BANTAM BAY



Date December 27, 1601–January 1, 1602
Forces Dutch: 3 ships, 2 yachts; Portuguese: 8 galleons, 22 other vessels
Losses Dutch: none; Portuguese: 3 fustas captured
Location Sunda Strait, western Java

On April 23, 1601, five ships sailed from the Netherlands for Indonesia—then known as the East Indies or simply the Spice Islands. Calling itself the Moluccan Fleet, this flotilla was commanded by Admiral Wolphert Harmensz and consisted of three armed merchantmen and two yachts—fast lightly armed ships used as scouts. The Moluccan Fleet was intended to break the Portuguese monopoly of the spice trade. Portuguese sailors had dominated the Indian Ocean for almost a century, but they were ill-prepared to meet a ruthless challenge from an aggressive European arrival. Harmensz's ships appeared off the Javanese port of Bantam, a major center for the export of pepper, at Christmas 1601. The Portuguese had a superior force of galleons and fustas—light galleys—in harbor, but when skirmishing began they had the worst of it. On January 1, the Portuguese abandoned the port, which became the Indian Ocean headquarters of the newly formed Dutch East India Company.



Horary quadrant
Used for telling the time by the angle of the sun, the quadrant has a scale that is adjusted for every day of the year.

EIGHTY YEARS WAR

GIBRALTAR



Date April 25, 1607
Forces Dutch: 26 ships; Spanish: 21 ships
Losses Dutch: none; Spanish: 21 ships destroyed
Location Bay of Gibraltar

In early April 1607 a fleet of 26 small but well-armed Dutch warships set sail for the Iberian peninsula, accompanied by four supply ships. In command was the audacious and experienced Jacob van Heemskerk on board *Aeolus*. Arriving off Lisbon, he learned that a Spanish war fleet was in the Strait of Gibraltar and headed south to engage it. The Dutch found ten large Spanish galleons—far bigger ships than any of their own—and a number of lesser vessels anchored in Gibraltar Bay. Van Heemskerk decided to attack. He knew his ships would have no chance to withdraw if the battle went against them—there would be, he told his captains, "no choice between triumph and destruction."

The Spanish fleet was under the command of Admiral Don Juan Álvarez de Ávila, a veteran of Lepanto. He was astonished by the presumption of the small Dutch ships, which sailed fearlessly into the bay, drifting gradually toward his galleons in a faint wind. Van Heemskerk's plan was for two ships to place themselves alongside each galleon, firing point-blank broadsides into both sides of the hull. His *Aeolus* was to engage the Spanish flagship *San Augustin*, with *Tiger* on the other side. During the long slow approach the Dutch held their fire, the gunners ordered to wait until the ships were hull-to-hull. In the first broadsides van Heemskerk was fatally wounded, his leg torn off by a cannonball. De Ávila was also killed immediately. The carnage as the Dutch ships fired into galleons packed with soldiers was appalling. Several galleons were set ablaze and reduced to burning hulks, drifting out of control onto shore. Other Spanish ships were sunk. One exploded as a shot ignited its powder store, showering blazing debris across the smoke-darkened bay. *San Augustin* was the last to succumb, boarded from both sides. The fighting ended toward sunset, but not the slaughter. The Dutch sailors rowed boats around the wreckage-strewn bay shooting or stabbing Spaniards who had leaped into the water from their burning ships. Around 4,000 Spanish sailors and soldiers are reckoned to have lost their lives; the Dutch dead numbered about one hundred. Van Heemskerk was awarded a hero's funeral in Amsterdam.



Death by fire and water
The battle of Gibraltar saw the total destruction of the Spanish fleet. Here, one of the Spanish galleons explodes as it is hit in the powder magazine.